and not exactly black and white. Despite intercepting chatter about the Lashkar-e-Taiba's (LeT) plan to carry out terror attacks on Indian soil, the listening devices were not able to decode what was going on in Hafiz Saeed's mind. Where was he planning to attack? How was he going to execute it? Senior R&AW officials involved in counterterrorism sometimes wonder: If they'd had a mole inside the LeT, would 26 November 2008 have been just another day in Mumbai?

Chanakya's words on espionage clear up all doubts related to the need for human spies. He said: A king needs trusted spies not just to steal the secrets of his enemies but to also to sow seeds of dissension among the opposition. A fiery spy working undercover can change the destiny of a nation.

Chinese military strategist Sun Tzu said: 'If you know the enemy and know yourself, you need not fear the results of a hundred battles.'

These words are as true today as they were in the fifth century BC. That's why, though digital intelligence has revolutionised the working style of spy organisations across the globe, it has not been able to replace the ruthless efficiency of an agent on the ground.

Since 2008, India's intelligence gathering agency, like those of the rest of the world, began focusing on both digital and traditional espionage methods to keep pace with technological advances. The R&AW began to expand its HUMINT networks across the subcontinent and also formed a separate division for cyber espionage. A specialised group within the R&AW monitors secret codes, particularly in regional languages, that are used by foreign based anti-social elements to disseminate mischievous messages through social media platforms. Today,